

Why do I have to wait for my game to be fun?

Instant gratification. “Why do I need to play a game for xx-hours before it gets good?” It’s a very valid question, and one I’ve often had myself.

I’ve been gaming for close to 20 years, and reviewing games for over 10 years now. I know the frustration of needing to slog through needlessly long segments in games before the “real magic” happens. Now in my case, it was literally my job, I had to push through. But for everyone else? It can feel like wasted time, wasted time that you spent money on no less. It’s totally fair to expect to enjoy something you spent your money on from the get-go. However, is it fair to dismiss a game outright just because it doesn’t grab us immediately?

I don’t think it is. The argument “Why do I need to play a game for xx-hours before it gets good?” oversimplifies things. Games are complex storytelling and entertainment mediums, and it’s important to realise that not all games are built the same. There are plenty of titles out there that are designed to offer instant gratification, while there are others that aim for a gradual build-up that rewards players for their patience and investment. Several iconic games, like Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild, The Witcher 3, Dark Souls and more aren’t games that show you their full potential within the first hour of gameplay.

They encourage exploration, mastery over the game’s controls, and even practice. This in-turn rewards players with a sense of accomplishment and achievement that I believe is deeply tied with the

amount of enjoyment players derive from such games.

Another thing the argument implies is that worth of a game is entirely reliant on the first few hours of gameplay. Like with most of the games we’ve mentioned above, that’s not always the case. It’s like judging a book by its first few chapters and you might just miss out on a fantastic game because of that. Games like The Witcher 3, which features amazing storytelling and beautifully written characters, takes some time to fully develop. However, the game doesn’t have what we might call a “gripping” beginning; dismissing the game simply because of that isn’t really fair.

Of course, the only reason the argument arose in the first place is because this does actually happen. The gaming industry isn’t without flaws. Developers have been known to intentionally force players through tedious, grindy segments to not only pad the game’s playtime, but make the fun bits seem like more fun. In such cases the criticism is totally valid. It’s important to differentiate between games that genuinely suffer from poor pacing to those that intentionally build up to something grand.

Of course, there’s also personal preference. Ultimately, the kind of games you enjoy are purely subjective. As a fan of RPGs and MMORPGs, I’m used to slow starts that scale to epic proportions. However, someone else might find this quite dull. I personally enjoy the challenge of mastering complex systems and mechanics, but others may enjoy a slower, more casual experience.



Manish “Trigger-Happy” Rajesh

SKOAR! Overlord
feedback@skoar.in

When it comes to gaming, patience can indeed be a virtue. While the “xx-hour” rule has its merits, keep in mind that not all games are meant to grip you instantly. So, maybe the next time you find yourself tempted to toss aside a game that’s been a bit of a slog, just remember that treasures may await those who dare to venture a little deeper. *